

Ukraine — African Countries

Communication Strategy

2024-2026

Key Approaches and Principles

Current Situation and Problem Statement

In 2021-2022, the efforts of Ukrainian diplomacy led to a significant increase in fruitful cooperation between Ukraine and African countries. In January 2022, for the first time ever, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Ukraine adopted a Strategy for the Development of Relations between Ukraine and African States. A significant step in strengthening interaction between Ukraine and African countries was the appointment of a Special Representative of Ukraine for the Middle East and Africa in July 2022.

The intensification of relations is also reflected in the growing number and substance of bilateral and multilateral cooperation formats. In particular, from February 2022 to February 2024, the President of Ukraine held more than 30 meetings with leaders of African countries and pan-African organizations. The state leadership made a strategic decision to increase Ukraine's presence on the African continent, and in December 2022, announced the opening of 10 new Ukrainian embassies across Africa. During 2022-2023, the Minister of Foreign Affairs, as part of the New Horizons strategy, undertook four extensive diplomatic tours of Africa, visiting 12 countries across the continent: Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, Kenya, Morocco, Ethiopia, Mozambique, Rwanda, Nigeria, Equatorial Guinea, Liberia, and South Africa. Most of these visits were made by Ukraine's Foreign Minister for the first time in the history of diplomatic relations between Ukraine and these countries.

This unprecedented focus on African countries and consistent political engagement demonstrate modern Ukraine's aspiration to effectively participate in the continent's strategic processes. Ukraine aims to strengthen ties with African nations, expand its presence, and foster cultural and people-to-people exchange. Given the current geopolitical and economic landscape, Ukraine should build its relationships with African partners on a systematic, flexible, and adaptable foundation. This necessitates a deep understanding of the complex and diverse developmental realities of individual African states and pan-African integration organizations, as well as the multifaceted nature of each sub-region.

Despite the geographical distance and cultural diversity of Africa, Ukraine and the countries of the continent share a history of struggle for freedom, building independence, finding their place on the world stage, and establishing state and national identity. However, the current geopolitical situation, including Russia's full-scale armed aggression against Ukraine and global security challenges for many African countries, has highlighted the critical need to introduce new approaches to Ukraine's communication with them. These approaches should be grounded in a clear understanding of Africa's pivotal role in the present and future global order, its significance in Ukrainian foreign policy, and the imperative of enhancing Ukraine's visibility on the continent. Additionally, a comprehensive strategy to counter disinformation and propaganda is essential.

The first-ever Ukraine-African countries Communication Strategy (hereinafter referred to as the Strategy) of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Ukraine aims to fully reflect the importance and diversity of Ukraine's relations with the countries of the continent and to establish mechanisms for a robust strategic partnership. Several African countries are emerging as significant global players, and Ukraine should capitalize on this potential by incorporating it into its economic, political, and diplomatic relations. It is essential to acknowledge that Ukraine's diplomacy has historically underemphasized comprehensive cooperation with African countries, particularly those in West, Central, Eastern, and Southern Africa. A key objective for the next three years is to rectify this oversight by transitioning from ad hoc cooperation to consistent and comprehensive diplomatic engagement in all African regions.

The Strategy outlines specific steps aimed at deepening and expanding Ukraine's communication with African countries, including communication support for various initiatives to fight for the rule of law, strengthen the economic independence of our societies, enhance food security, and increase trade, investment, and cultural exchange.

Some unprecedented shifts in relations between Ukraine and African countries are already evident including the following support for Ukraine by some previously emphatically neutral African countries during the UNGA votes; increased diplomatic activity by several African leaders; proposals to resume grain exports; revitalization of trade and economic activity, etc. However, Ukraine must intensify efforts to build upon these achievements. Ukrainian policy in this area should be systematic, consistent, long-term, and effective.

As Ukraine seeks to forge stronger ties and meaningful cooperation with the dynamic African continent, it is crucial to dispel outdated perceptions and acknowledge Africa's multifaceted and diverse nature. We view Africa not as a monolithic entity, but as a mosaic of 54 sovereign states, each possessing a unique blend of political, economic, cultural, and religious identities. Recognizing the immense potential of African countries, Ukraine is committed to establishing friendly and equitable relationships without intermediaries, revitalizing existing bilateral and multilateral partnerships, and embarking on a new era of cooperation. Together, we will strive for progress grounded in mutual respect, shared interests, and reciprocal benefits. Strategic communications are indispensable for laying the groundwork and facilitating the implementation of our new policy towards Africa. While we are only beginning this journey, we are confident it will lead to a flourishing partnership and a shared future characterized by inclusivity, justice, and prosperity.

Main Principles

Proactivity

Purposefulness and initiative in shaping the information environment, extending beyond reactive responses to the activities of other participants in the communication process.

Simplicity

Clear, understandable, explicit, and consistent key messages and actions to achieve strategic communication goals and objectives.

«One voice» Policy

Integrated and coordinated communication efforts among the diplomatic missions of Ukraine abroad, the MFA central office, other government agencies, and officials responsible for Ukraine's foreign policy communication.

Innovation

Utilization of both traditional and cutting-edge communication and information methods.

Adaptability

Consideration of local peculiarities and regional context in communication and information activities.

Credibility

Ensuring that communication is truthful and trustworthy, based on factual data, counteracting distortion or misrepresentation of information, and preventing communication based on inaccurate or unverified data.

Reciprocity

Communication based on dialogue and reciprocity with target audiences, groups, and participants of communication relations, aimed at building mutual respect and trust between participants. Dialogue-driven communication fostering mutual respect and trust among target audiences, groups, and communication participants.

Result-Oriented Approach

Continuous, conscious, and proactive achievement of strategy and related document goals and objectives, delivered on time and with measurable efficiency.

Framework for Developing the Strategy

In development of the Strategy, we relied on the Communication Strategy of the MFA of Ukraine (March 2021), the Public Diplomacy Strategy of the MFA of Ukraine (March 2021), the Strategy of Ukraine's Relations with African States (January 2022), and several analytical studies conducted by the MFA and expert non-governmental organizations. The Department of Public Diplomacy and Communication of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Ukraine conducted a general analysis of media consumption in Africa, an analysis of local media languages, an audit of the communication capabilities of Ukraine's diplomatic missions in Africa, and the current staffing situation. Additionally, the MFA's monitoring and analytical data on Ukraine-related narratives in African media during 2022-2023 served as valuable input.

The Term of Action and Its Justification

The Strategy is valid for 3 years

Despite Russia's unprovoked full-scale aggression against Ukraine and ongoing efforts to liberate Ukrainian territories, Ukraine remains steadfast in pursuing its strategic interests in Africa and developing a mutually beneficial post-war partnership. This Strategy outlines a roadmap for 2024-2026.

A three-year timeframe offers sufficient opportunity to implement and assess the effectiveness of various communication initiatives, enabling adjustments in response to evolving conditions, such as political and economic developments in Ukraine, African countries, and globally. By setting clear communication objectives and timelines for engagement with African nations, Ukraine can optimize its position to achieve long-term sustainable development and mutually beneficial partnerships on the continent.

After the end of the war, shaping Ukraine's post-war image in Africa will be a paramount focus for Ukraine and the MFA. Strategically, efforts will center on positioning Ukraine as a dependable and influential political and economic partner, countering disinformation and propaganda, and establishing or reforming international platforms for multilateral cooperation grounded in justice, peace, friendship, equality, and transparency. A top priority will be the multifaceted development of economic ties, including leveraging Ukraine's agricultural strengths to address Africa's food security challenges.

Key Countries

Key Criteria Used to Identify Key Countries for Ukraine's Strategic Communication



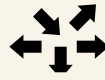
Economic Potential

Countries with substantial trade and economic potential, existing significant bilateral trade, and promising growth prospects are prioritized. Strategic communication focuses on positioning Ukraine as a reliable economic partner, highlighting agricultural, industrial, and investment opportunities.



Political Relevance

Countries with significant regional or global political influence, undergoing democratic transitions, or considered swing states in Africa are prioritized. Engaging with these countries fosters diplomatic alliances, defends shared values, and effectively addresses geopolitical challenges, including Russian aggression.



Multilateral Engagement

Countries actively involved in regional and global international organizations are key targets. Multilateral cooperation enhances Ukraine's diplomatic influence, authority, and ability to achieve global objectives.



Security Cooperation

States with potential for security cooperation and interest in counterterrorism are prioritized. Emphasizing Ukraine's commitment to global security builds partnerships and combats threats like terrorism, extremism, and food blackmail.



Ukraine's Communication Capabilities

The presence of Ukrainian diplomatic missions in the country, the developments in the chambers of commerce and industry, and the existence of a Ukrainian diaspora with extensive media ties are crucial factors for local communication efforts.



Diverse Media Landscape

Countries with diverse and robust media environments are ideal for Ukraine's communication efforts. Focusing on key media outlets and opinion leaders ensures accurate and compelling messaging to African governments and publics while countering disinformation.



Cultural Ties

States with existing historical and cultural ties to Ukraine or with the potential to develop such connections, including people-to-people ties, may be considered as a priority for communication activities to further strengthen friendship, mutual understanding, cultural exchange, and other types of cooperation.



Environmental Agenda

Joint counteraction to address global climate change, ecocide, natural and man-made disasters.

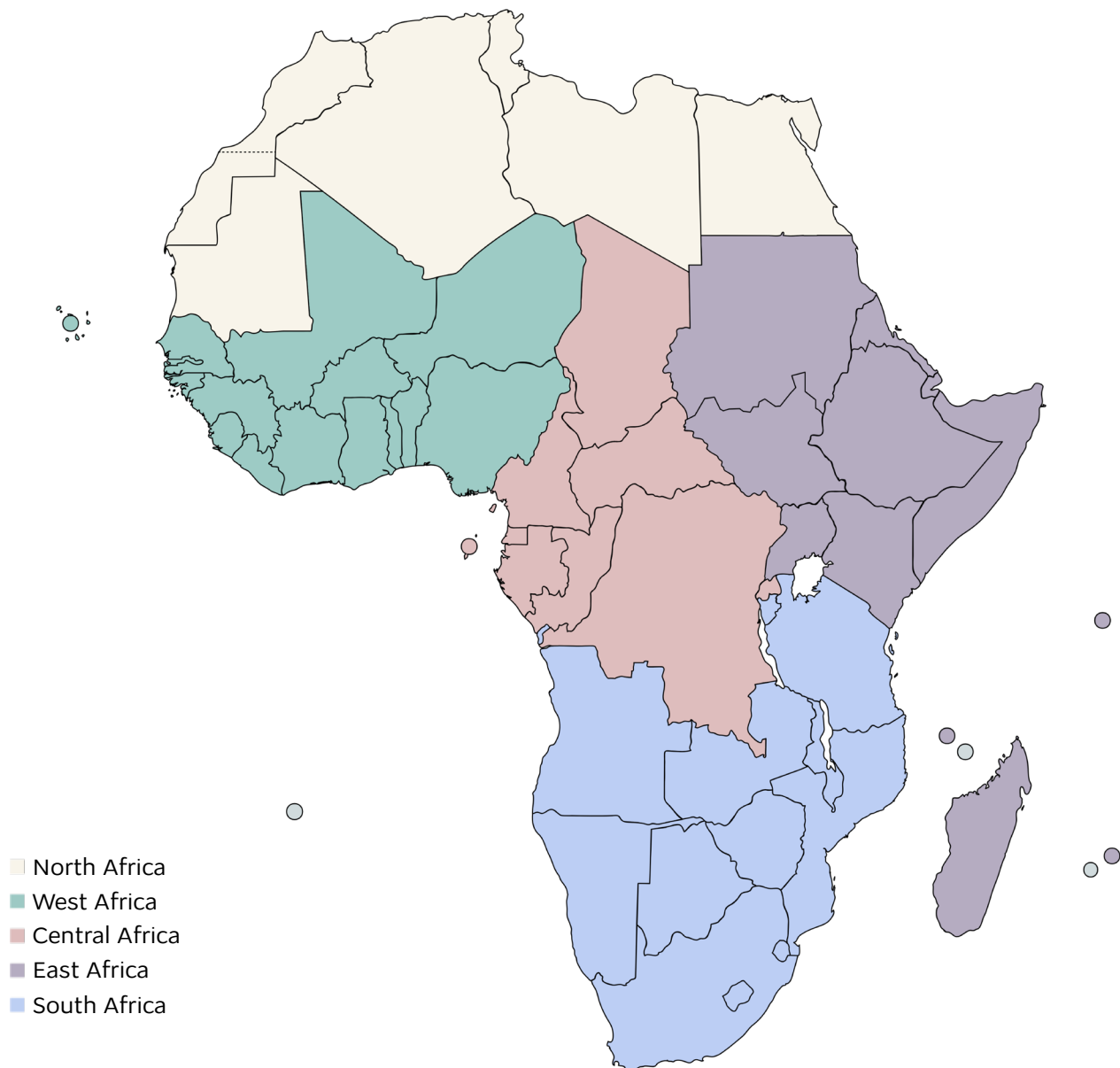


Humanitarian Engagement

Countries facing humanitarian challenges and receiving assistance from Ukraine are a special target of our communication activities. In the long run, they can demonstrate solidarity and provide support to Ukraine. The Strategy emphasizes Ukraine's commitment to humanitarian aid and its efforts to promote sustainable development in Africa.

Political and Economic Zoning of Africa

We believe it is appropriate to align Ukraine's regional framework for Africa with that of the African Union. When dividing into regions, the MFA relies on the unchanged official version of the regionalization of Africa, which was defined by the Organization of African Unity (OAU) in 1976. According to it, the member states of the African Union are divided into five geographical regions:

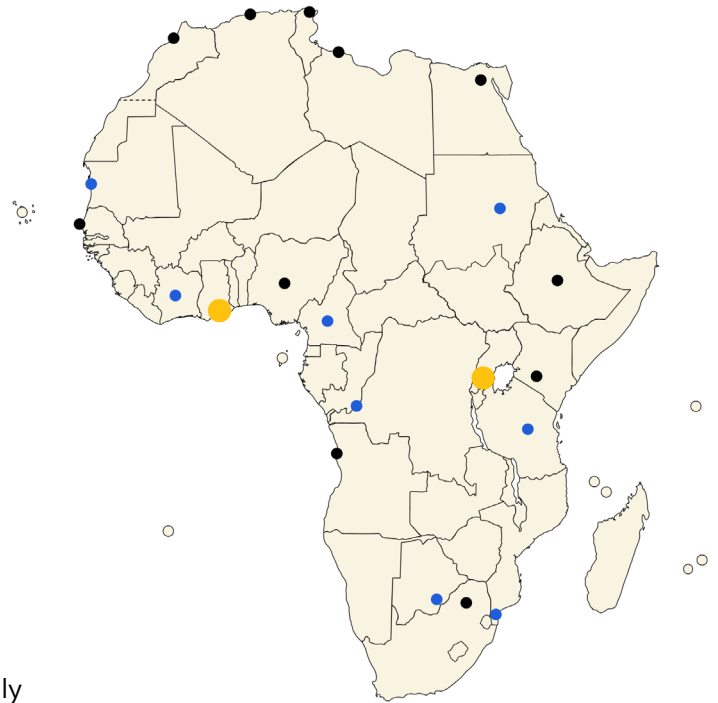


Prioritization of communications in each African sub-region was based on the probability of achieving desired outcomes within the Strategy's timeframe.

Communication Capacity of the MFA and Foreign Diplomatic Missions

Personnel Situation

Currently, Ukrainian diplomatic missions are open only in 13 countries (Algeria, Angola, Ethiopia, Egypt, Kenya, Morocco, Nigeria, South Africa, Senegal, Tunisia, Ghana, Rwanda, and Côte d'Ivoire), which is 18% of the continent's diplomatic coverage. Also, Ukrainian diplomatic missions are accredited in Mauritania and Mali (Permanent Mission of Ukraine in Algeria), Tanzania (Permanent Mission of Ukraine in Kenya), Cameroon (Permanent Mission of Ukraine in Nigeria), Botswana and Mozambique (Permanent Mission of Ukraine in South Africa). The Permanent Representation in Libya suspended operations in February 2015 due to deteriorating security conditions. The possibility of reopening the mission is contingent upon the stabilization of the situation and the establishment of legitimate governing institutions. Currently, the Embassy of Ukraine in Tunisia oversees affairs related to Libya.



- Active UA embassies
- Upcoming UA embassies
- Recently opened UA embassies

The planned opening of 7 more Ukrainian embassies in Africa

(Botswana, Cameroon, DR Congo, Mauritania, Mozambique, Sudan, and Tanzania)

will strengthen the communication capacity of the MFA and Ukraine's diplomatic missions abroad, which will intensify the promotion of Ukrainian narratives and Ukraine's positive image on the continent.

A 2023 internal audit of communication capacity at diplomatic missions revealed that each African mission currently designates a media relations officer. However, due to the limited staffing situation, all these officers are also responsible for other areas. While most diplomats are proficient in one or two official languages of their host country, this is frequently insufficient given the number of countries under their purview and the prevalence of local languages. For instance, the Embassy in South Africa covers ten countries where, in addition to English, French, or Portuguese, dozens of other languages hold official status.

Communication challenges also exist in languages widely spoken by citizens in accreditation and host countries, including Hausa, Igbo, and Yoruba (Nigeria); Zulu, Xhosa, and Sotho (South Africa); Wolof (Senegal); Swahili (Kenya, Tanzania); Amazigh/Tamazight (Morocco); Amharic and Oromo (Ethiopia); Kinyarwanda (Rwanda); Akan (Ghana, Côte d'Ivoire); Lingala (DR Congo); and others. To address this, Ukraine's foreign diplomatic missions should bolster their capacity by hiring language specialists and partnering with local communication experts.

Purpose, Goals, Objectives

The Main Purpose of the Strategy

Effective development of a clear, effective, coordinated architecture of the MFA's external communications aimed at strengthening support for Ukraine in the fight against Russian aggression and developing strategic long-term, mutually beneficial, and friendly relations with the countries of the African continent.



Strategic Goals

- 1 Promote the image of Ukraine in Africa as a free, independent, strong, sovereign state.
- 2 Strengthen the perception of Ukraine in African countries, which will contribute to strengthening their support for Ukraine in international cooperation formats.
- 3 Ensure the official condemnation of Russian armed aggression by as many African states as possible.
- 4 Ensure a favorable attitude of internal and external audiences to Ukraine's policy towards African countries.



Communication Goals

- 1 Strengthen and further promote the holistic image of Ukraine in Africa as an independent and sovereign state with its own distinctive history, language, culture, and technologically advanced armed forces.
- 2 Improve the perception of Ukraine as a stable, reliable, and desirable partner that respects African countries and understands their needs.
- 3 Inform target audiences in African states about the repercussions of Russia's aggression against Ukraine, emphasizing its detrimental impact on the African continent.
- 4 Foster clear and compelling communication of Ukraine's foreign policy initiatives across the continent to both domestic and international audiences.



Objectives

- 1 Maintain a consistent, strong Ukrainian presence in Africa at both official and unofficial levels, including media engagement.
- 2 Provide communication support to diplomatic missions in key countries and facilitate the revitalization of official communication channels in locations where new embassies are planned.
- 3 Monitor and counteract the spread of anti-Ukrainian narratives, disinformation, propaganda, and fake news in Africa.
- 4 Engage opinion leaders, key media, experts, civil society, and Ukrainian diaspora to coordinate and promote pro-Ukraine narratives in key African countries.
- 5 Systematically work with official and public circles in Africa to convey the truth about Russia's unprovoked full-scale aggression against Ukraine to African officials and publics:
 - 5.1. Secure recognition of Russia's invasion as a crime of aggression.
 - 5.2. Expose the inhumane and genocidal nature of Russia's war.
 - 5.3. Demonstrate real examples of Russia's consistent aggressive policies towards Ukraine and other neighboring countries, its intentions to conquer peoples and nations, dominate them by denying and destroying their identities.
 - 5.4. Build confidence in Ukraine's ability to defeat Russian occupation forces with international support.
- 6 Promote the independence and territorial integrity of states within internationally recognized borders and advocate for lasting peace in Ukraine as a cornerstone of African stability.

- 7 Highlight Ukraine's potential for defense cooperation and express its readiness to partner with African countries on security and defense.
- 8 Strengthen narratives supporting global efforts to hold aggressors accountable.
 - 8.1. Promote the Ukrainian Formula for Peace as a roadmap to sustainable and lasting peace.
- 9 Demonstrate the negative impact of Russia's policies on global food security, showcase Ukraine's role in grain exports to Africa, and implement additional food initiatives.
- 10 Establish communication channels through cultural diplomacy and partnerships with cultural and diplomatic institutions.
- 11 Ensure a clear communication policy of «one voice», and prevent the spread of fakes and anti-Ukrainian speculations.
- 12 Track shifts in public opinion in African countries through polling and monitoring.
- 13 Enhance Ukrainian public understanding of the government's new Africa policies.



Expected Results of Communication Goals

- 1 Target audiences recognize Ukraine as a free, sovereign nation with a distinct history, culture, and formidable armed forces.
- 2 Audiences perceive strengthened bilateral trade, economic, diplomatic, political, and other relations with Ukraine as mutually beneficial.
- 3 Audiences are aware of the devastating consequences of Russia's aggression:
 - for Ukraine (war crimes, genocide, humanitarian catastrophe), and can draw parallels with their own post-colonial experience.
- 4 Audiences comprehend the challenges Ukraine faces in Africa and support its foreign policy initiatives.
 - for African countries (food blackmail, inflation, lack of «added value» in Russia's actions to ensure the economic development of African countries, activities of private military companies, propaganda of coups, incitement to hatred, radicalization, illegal exploitation of resources, political and economic stagnation etc.)

Target Audiences and Communication Channels



Target Audiences

Internal

- Representatives of governments and governmental organizations, political circles of Ukraine, and central executive authorities of Ukraine.
- Ukrainian expert organizations and representatives of academic circles whose scientific and/or expert interests include the African continent or its countries.
- Leaders of Ukrainian civil society, including youth organizations.
- Representatives of the Ukrainian media and cultural community.
- Ukrainian businesses that are present or interested in entering the African continent.

External

- Representatives of governments and governmental organizations, political circles of African countries.
- Representatives of international organizations and missions operating in Africa.
- Civil society leaders and opinion leaders, human rights defenders, representatives of non-governmental organizations, and oversight bodies in Africa.
- Representatives of education, think tanks, and researchers from African countries.
- Cultural representations of partner countries on the African continent.
- Media representatives: journalists, reporters, editors; local top bloggers, and influencers.
- Representatives of large and medium-sized businesses at the management level (decision makers).
- Representatives of the Ukrainian community and their organizations/associations.
- Youth representatives and youth organizations from Africa.
- Politically active citizens of African countries who are interested in world events, and economic and cultural transformations and follow the news.



Channels of Communication

Internal

- Official communication channels of key authorities, including the official website of the MFA of Ukraine, social media pages, and information channels of the Ministry's officials, such as the Minister, the Spokesperson, and other authorized spokespersons of the MFA.
- Official websites and social media pages of ministries and their heads, central executive authorities.
- Official websites and social media pages of Ukrainian experts, public, non-governmental, and human rights organizations, etc. Representatives of the Ukrainian media and cultural community.
- Information resources of representative offices of international organizations in Ukraine, including funds for international scientific and technical cooperation.

- Official websites and social media pages of Ukrainian higher education institutions.
- Ukrainian media, including television, print and online media, and journalists from these media.

- Information channels of youth organizations, including international ones.
- Opinion leaders and influential/prominent Ukrainians, including representatives of the diaspora.

External

- Official websites of diplomatic missions in Africa, pages of diplomatic missions, and their heads on social media (Facebook, X, Instagram, YouTube, Telegram, LinkedIn, etc.).
- Official websites and social media pages of foreign experts and research organizations operating on the African continent or in individual African countries.
- Communication channels of international organizations and conferences broadcast to African audiences.
- Websites of cultural missions of Ukraine's partner countries on the African continent.
- National and regional TV channels of key African countries.

- Media resources of African media (TV, radio, online, print, social media) and journalists of these publications.
- Information channels of leading educational institutions in Africa.
- Communication resources of opinion leaders, including bloggers and influencers.
- Ukrainian media broadcasting in foreign languages to foreign audiences, including those in Africa (United24media, Ukraine.ua, etc.).

Languages of Communication

For Internal Communication

Ukrainian

For External Communication

Official languages of the host countries are required

Given the diversity of official languages and the prevalence of local languages in African countries, it's crucial to consider the number of speakers and prioritize communication in these languages.

Local media and communication partners can provide translation and communication services into official languages not covered by current or future diplomatic mission staff.

In countries where English or French is not widely used in daily life, or where European languages are not primary or secondary languages, communication in local languages fosters greater trust in the information provided.

Monitoring and Evaluation of the Strategy Implementation

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs' Department of Public Diplomacy and Communications is responsible for effectively monitoring and evaluating Strategy implementation. The results of monitoring may serve as a basis for adjusting information messages and approving the action plan for the next year. The basic indicators for monitoring and evaluating the implementation of the Strategy are set out in Table 1.

Table 1: Key indicators for monitoring and evaluation of the Strategy implementation

Objectives	Indicators	Evaluation and Monitoring Tools
Strengthen and further promote the holistic image of Ukraine in Africa as an independent and sovereign state with its own distinctive history, language, culture, and technologically advanced armed forces.	Percentage of target audience representatives who unequivocally perceive Ukraine as an independent, sovereign state within internationally recognized borders. Number and scope of communication projects and activities implemented by the MFA and Foreign Ministry in Africa to shape and strengthen the perception of Ukraine as an independent, sovereign state within internationally recognized borders.	Public opinion polls, online analytics tools, and media monitoring. Annual evaluation of action plans implemented by Ukrainian diplomatic missions to execute the MFA's Communication Strategy for African countries.
Improve the perception of Ukraine as a stable, reliable, and desirable partner that respects African countries and understands their needs.	Number of statements and decisions adopted or supported by African authorities in support of Ukraine, including recognition of its sovereignty and territorial integrity, condemnation of Russia's unprovoked aggression, and other relevant initiatives or decisions, including at the international level. Percentage of target audience representatives who publicly support Ukraine's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Number and scope of joint public diplomacy and international cooperation projects between Ukraine, African countries, and pan-African organizations or institutions aimed at establishing, expanding, and strengthening bilateral and multilateral ties promoting freedom and democracy.	Monitoring public statements, decisions of African countries' officials, diplomatic channels, and voting records in international organizations. Conducting public opinion polls, online analytics, and media monitoring. Annually evaluating the implementation of the action plan developed by Ukraine's diplomatic missions to execute the MFA's Communication Strategy for African countries.

Objectives	Indicators	Evaluation and Monitoring Tools
Inform target audiences in African states about the repercussions of Russia's aggression against Ukraine, emphasizing its detrimental impact on the African continent.	Percentage of target audience representatives who perceive the impact of Russia's aggression against Ukraine on African countries and the continent as overwhelmingly negative, specifically recognizing the detrimental economic and political consequences for Africa. Percentage of African politicians, diplomats, media, and experts who acknowledge the negative impact of Russia's aggression on African countries, demonstrate a willingness to study this impact, and actively work to mitigate its consequences for Ukraine, Africa, and the global community. Number and scope of communication projects of the MFA and Ukraine's diplomatic institutions aimed at increasing awareness of the impact on the African continent of Russia's war against Ukraine.	Scientific and expert research, public opinion surveys, online analytics, media monitoring, and reports from scientific, analytical, economic, and other centers. Annual evaluation of the action plan implemented by Ukraine's diplomatic missions to execute the MFA's Communication Strategy for African countries.
Foster clear and compelling communication of Ukraine's foreign policy initiatives across the continent to both domestic and international audiences.	Number and scope of communication projects undertaken by the MFA and Ukraine's diplomatic missions in African countries aim to establish and strengthen enduring communication ties between Ukraine and African countries.	Public opinion research, media monitoring, and reporting. Annual evaluation of the implementation of the action plan developed by the DPD for the implementation of the MFA's Communication Strategy for African countries.